

saving for retirement is much, much easier if you get started when you are young. As you will learn, saving for retirement is really just long-term investing, so the earlier you can get started, the earlier you can take advantage of compound interest.

When it comes to financial security in retirement, America's official motto for its elderly population is "good luck." We promote rugged individualism and independence as national virtues, and our approach to retirement is no different. While other countries have larger social programs and services for the elderly, Americans are more responsible for their own retirement and how comfortable or difficult their lives will be once they stop working. We do offer our citizens **Social Security**, a monthly check that people receive in retirement to help pay for living expenses, but as of 2020 the average monthly check was only \$1,503.⁴⁵ If you do not already own a home when you retire, that amount of money can be impossible to survive on. Furthermore, unless drastic changes are made to our government programs, Social Security may be even less reliable by the time the younger generation retires.

However, retirement can be a beautiful thing. If you have saved enough money during your working years, your retirement may consist of playing golf, traveling the country in an RV, or clubbing in after-hours parties in L.A.—whatever floats your boat. If, however, you have not saved enough money for retirement, you may have to work much longer than you would like to, or your life after work may be a lot more stressful than anticipated.

45 "What Is the Maximum Social Security Benefit?," American Association of Retired Persons (AARP), last modified December 16, 2019, <https://www.aarp.org/retirement/social-security/questions-answers/maximum-ss-benefit.html>.